

The green-eyed monster

One of the things that can seriously detract from our baseline happiness and make it more difficult for us to jump off the hedonic treadmill is envy. Envy is part of being human, but God knows it's not the nicest feeling in the world. I do often think that envy gets a bad rap, considering it's something that we all feel, at least from time to time – and something that we have absolutely no control over at that. It's seen as an ugly trait, something to be ashamed of, especially if what we're coveting is money.

Envy can actually be useful in some ways, because it can help us to figure out what we want. For most of us, envy isn't about not wanting to see other people being successful, rather that we want some of that success for ourselves – and there is plenty of success to go around. I've had to work through a lot of money-related envy in my life, particularly in the second half of my twenties, when I was struggling to balance the books and cover childcare while my close childhood friends bought houses and went on far-flung holidays. It wasn't that I didn't want those things for them – of course I did – but I wanted them too. The main thing that I was envious of, though, was the peace of mind that seemed to come with being free to make positive decisions with money. All of my own decisions at the time were based on what would be the least bad outcome – I was fighting fires rather than building anything. I was envious of the fact that they didn't have the burden of their poor decisions weighing down on